

751–760



The interior of the Mosque of Cordoba, Spain, shows architecture from the earliest phase of construction during the reign of Abd al-Rahman I.

UNDER THE NEW ABBASID

CALIPHS (see 741–50) the Islamic Empire continued to grow. Initial success came in 751 against the Chinese in the Silk Route kingdom of Tashkent. The Islamic armies were victorious at the **Battle of Talas River** near Samarkand,

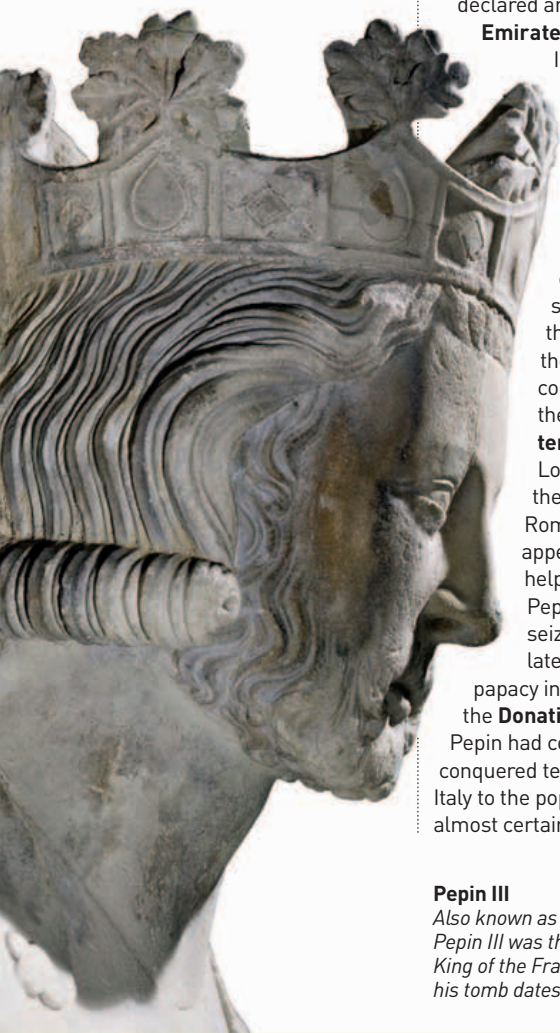
which led to the loss of most of Tang China's Central Asian possessions and introduced the Islamic world to **papermaking**. Outlying regions of the caliphate asserted their autonomy. In Spain in 756, one of the last surviving Umayyads, Abd al-Rahman I, declared an independent

Emirate of Cordoba.

In Europe, the Carolingian Pepin III (c. 714–68) **deposed the last Merovingian king**, Childeric III. With the pope's support **Pepin was crowned** and was soon able to return the papal favor. When the Lombards conquered Ravenna, the **last Byzantine territory in Italy**, the Lombard king, Aistulf then set his eyes on Rome. Pope Stephen II appealed to Pepin for help, and in 755 and 756 Pepin invaded Italy, seizing Ravenna. It was later claimed by the papacy in a document entitled the **Donation of Pepin**, that Pepin had conceded all former conquered territories in northern Italy to the pope, but this was almost certainly not the case.

Pepin III

Also known as *Pepin the Short*, Pepin III was the first Carolingian King of the Franks. This carving from his tomb dates to the 13th century.



761–770



The two-tier crop rotation system introduced in the 760s divided fields between cultivated and fallow land, then alternated, promoting soil fertility.

THE DEATH OF PEPIN III IN 758,

had seen the Frankish kingdom customarily divided between his sons Carloman and Charles (see panel, below).

Meanwhile, the great monastic retreat on the Scottish **isle of Iona** was developing a reputation for piety and scholarship. It is possible that one of the treasures of Celtic Christianity—the **Book of Kells**—was produced by monks in the monastery at Iona. Lavishly decorated and illuminated, this priceless artifact survived the Viking raids (see 791–800), and for safekeeping it was later transferred to a monastery at Kells in Ireland.

The **founding of Baghdad** in 762 signaled the arrival of the first truly Islamic imperial city. Sited near Ctesiphon (the old



Sasanian capital), the new city was carefully laid out on a circular plan and was connected to the Tigris and Euphrates rivers by canals. Baghdad became a trading hub that attracted merchants from northern Europe, India, and China.



CHARLEMAGNE (748–814)

Athletic and physically impressive, Charlemagne spoke Latin and understood Greek, but never learned to read. His intent was to extend Frankish hegemony, foster a close relationship with the papacy, and reform the Church to ensure divine support for the Frankish Kingdom. This depiction from a 15th century tapestry is testament his enduring legacy.

771–780



Roland bids farewell to Charlemagne, in this medieval illustration on vellum.

Charlemagne's European Conquests

Charlemagne inherited land from his father then embarked on war after war, continuing the work of his father and grandfather.

KEY

- Frankish Empire on Charlemagne's accession
- Charlemagne's conquests
- Regions recognizing Charlemagne as overlord

THE DEATH OF CARLOMAN IN 771

meant that Charlemagne became sole ruler of the Franks. The following year he launched a series of bloody campaigns with the aim of bringing the peoples east of the Rhine back under Frankish rule—they had been subject to the authority of the preceding Merovingian Dynasty. At this time the various Saxon tribes were still pagans, and Charlemagne was determined to convert them to Christianity and thus bring them under the hegemony of the Frankish state. From 773–74 he conquered the kingdom of the Lombards, **bringing northern Italy into his empire** and establishing his rule over Venetia, Dalmatia, and Corsica, thus extending his reach down both sides of the Adriatic coast and into the Mediterranean. In the late 770s, he attempted to **project his power into Spain** by taking advantage of infighting among the Muslim rulers. Invited to intervene in local politics by disgruntled emirs, Charlemagne

